

Peer pressure

During adolescence, friends play bigger roles in teens' lives. They can influence and inspire them—just as during adulthood. The opposite can also be true: in emotional situations, peer pressure can make some teens do things they're uncomfortable with.

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Understanding peer pressure

When a person feels influenced by their friends or peers to behave in a certain way and/or adopt a particular type of behavior, dress, or attitude in order to fit in, this is peer pressure. Feeling accepted is a strong driving force for people of all ages, and so learning how to deal with peer pressure—both positive and negative—is an important life skill.



△ One in a million

Many people—both adults and teens—find speaking against the majority, or acting differently from their peers, stressful.

Negative peer pressure

Peer pressure is usually perceived as something negative, such as when a person feels compelled by their peers—whether friends or not—to do something that they don't want to do. The teen years are a time when many people experiment and push boundaries, often because they want to impress their friends.

▽ Under pressure

Some teens may put pressure on others to take risks with them, and ridicule anyone who challenges them. There are different situations in which this might occur.

Looking a certain way

When a person thinks they look good, it makes them feel good, and the views of others can either reinforce that feeling or knock it down. Building self-confidence helps teens to feel assured—in themselves, in their individuality, and in how they look—and not to care so much about what their peers think, especially when their peers give them negative feedback.



Bragging on social media

Social media gives teens forums for sharing their thoughts and lives with a wide network of people. It can be easy to brag to attract comments and interest from others, but it's important to remember that the reaction they get from their peers might not be the one they were hoping for. Teens should be careful about what they post online, as such reactions can breed negativity that spirals out of control.



Risk-taking

While taking risks is part of growing up, individuals must make their own decisions about danger, as they will be the ones to suffer any consequences. It can be tempting to take chances to fit in, but having the confidence to say “no” puts a teen in charge of their actions, and shows inner strength.

